Catching the work

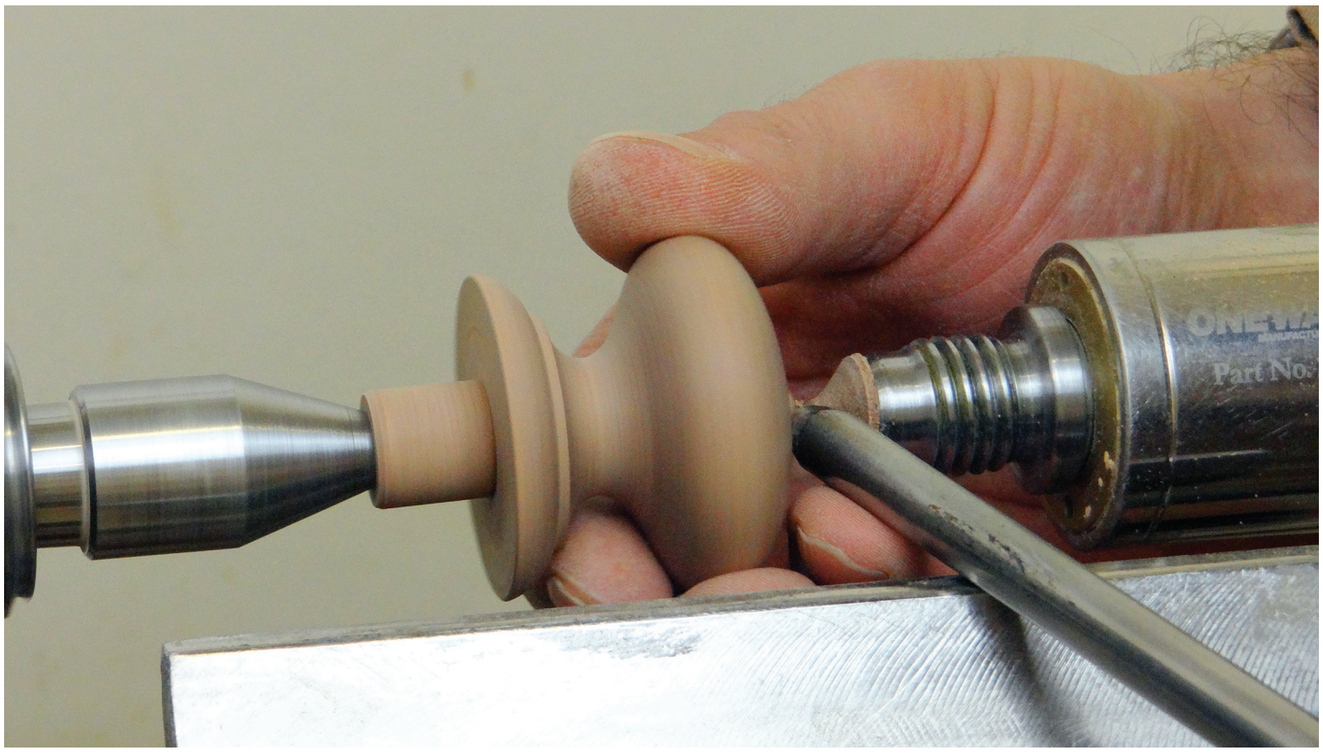
Something that is often overlooked when discussing parting off, is just how to catch the work once it is no longer held between centres. In my opinion as a left hander, this is one of the few times in life that being left handed is of huge benefit over being a righty. Right handers will find that they have to contort themselves, reaching over the headstock of the lathe, whereas lefties can catch the work in a very comfortable and normal turning position.

Whether you favour your left or right, the action is quite simple. However, as you progress through the cut, you can expect the work to do one of three things:

1. Drop neatly into your hand
2. Bind in the cut and mark the work with the waste piece or the tool
3. Spin out of centre and hit the toolrest before bouncing on the lathe bed and ending up on the floor

To ensure the outcome is option 1 rather than 2 or 3, you need to make sure you give yourself space to work by turning down the waste as small as possible. You can loosen the pressure between centres a little to avoid number 2 and cut in as smooth a fashion as possible to avoid number 3.

Keep your back hand loosely supporting the spinning work from the rear, as you make space in the waste. Once you are comfortable with everything, go for it. Don't rush or apply too much pressure, just continue the cut smoothly as normal. Remember the very centre of the work is spinning much slower than the outer edge, so proceed slowly and cut though the last few fibres. The work should simply stop spinning and come away, without any real drama, into the hand that is supporting the work. Done properly, this should be quite anticlimactic.



Parting should not be dramatic

TOP TIP:

If you aren't confident with the techniques for parting off, it isn't a problem. Take your work to the point where you would be ready to part, then remove it from the lathe and saw off the waste. A hand saw is always the safest option, but for small diameter work that is long enough to safely grip, you can use a bandsaw. Larger diameter work can still be cut on the bandsaw but a V-block should be used to support the work and avoid it spinning. Once sawn off, the tiny nib can be treated as described previously: removed and blended with abrasives. ●

Remove waste with a hand saw if you don't feel comfortable with parting on the lathe

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